

Myths and legends

For centuries, artists in many different societies have been commissioned to depict stories involving strong emotions and clear relationships to enlighten viewers. The ancient Greeks invented stories to venerate their gods. Similarly, from the fourth century CE, when Christianity became the main religion in Europe, artists were employed to translate the Bible into images to inform the populace and teach the illiterate.

Western painting developed through Church sponsorship, yet by c.1482, much art began once again to convey the things that Christianity had kept suppressed: the legends and myths of the pagan world. This was all part of Renaissance learning and humanism: as the philosophy and science of the ancient Greeks and Romans were rediscovered, so too were the myths. Once again, artists began interpreting stories in their own individual ways, and mythology soon became an excuse for artists in the Renaissance and later to paint with a flexibility and freedom of expression that was usually limited in Christian images.



Michelangelo, *Adam and Eve* from the Sistine Chapel ceiling, c.1510